CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

NAIL TECHNICIAN IN THE AI ERA

The ceiling is the story: the 90th percentile of nail techs earns about $50K. The median is $35,760.

★ TL;DR — NO — a low ceiling plus a substitute eating the beginner's book. BLS puts the manicurist median at $35,760 (May 2025) with +9% growth — but ~92% of the 21,900 yearly openings are replacement churn, and even the top decile only reaches ~$50,140. Meanwhile press-ons became the fastest-growing nail category of 2025, outselling traditional polish for the first time — an at-home substitute aimed exactly at the basic manicure a beginner lives on. The roadmap below is the way OUT. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

OUR TAKE: NO — NOT IN 2027

MEDIAN ~$36K · TRAINING 1-6 months · AI RISK LOW · CERTIFICATE

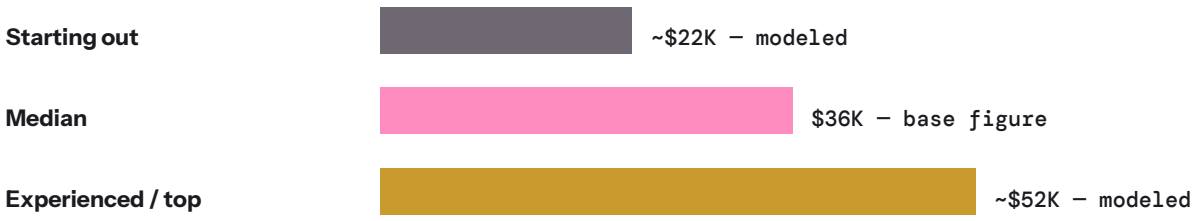
- Fails as a start because: the realistic year-1 anchor is the BLS 10th percentile, $28,920. Commission (typically 50/50, in a 40–60% range) pays only on services actually performed, so unbooked hours earn nothing beyond a minimum-wage top-up where the law requires one.

- The growth is churn: +9% on the headline, but only 18,600 net new jobs across the whole decade against 21,900 openings a year. The occupation refills its exits; it does not expand your odds.

- Still worth money: fine hand control, sanitation discipline and client care transfer straight into licensed skin work ($82,050 top decile) and pigment work ($400–$800 tickets) — seats whose ceilings are not welded shut.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Nail Technician is a ~$36K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A NAIL TECHNICIAN ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Shape, treat and polish natural nails; apply and maintain enhancements
- ✓ Create nail art from client photos and your own designs
- ✓ Sanitize tools and station to inspection standard between clients
- ✓ Manage bookings, supplies and rebooking

Think: miniature painting with a chemistry set, on a canvas that talks to you — and can now buy the painting as a press-on at home.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
The famous nail robot is a dead story: Clockwork's Target pilot (6 stores, $10 polish-only minicures — no filing, no cuticle work) ended on 20 Feb 2023 with Target stating it was 'not expanding the service'. No scaled deployment exists. Booking and design apps automate admin; nothing machines do touches the nail.	Cuticle judgment, product control, a steady hand at millimetre scale — and knowing when a nail needs care, not coating. The threat isn't a robot taking your chair; it's the client doing the basic version at home for a fraction of your ticket.

⚠ **Press-ons are not a fad footnote: artificial nails were 2025's fastest-growing nail category and passed traditional polish sales for the first time (Vertical IQ, citing Marie Claire/Circana data), with the press-on market projected from $738M (2024) toward $1,075M by 2030. Salons escape by going premium and custom — precisely the work a beginner doesn't do yet. Also price booth rent honestly before romanticising it: roughly $150–$600 a week depending on source and city, owed empty or full.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Detail work you can see and photograph daily ✓ Short training — the licence is genuinely quick (200–600 hours) ✓ Loyal regulars once your sets become their signature	✗ A ~$50K top-decile ceiling, ever ✗ Chemical smells and hunched posture all day ✗ Slow books mean unpaid hours on commission

Good fit? You already have paying clients lined up and treat the licence as a permit for a book that exists.
Bad fit? You're counting on the median in year one, or on basic manicures as the long-term product.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — PIVOT TO Esthetician	DOOR B — PIVOT TO Permanent Makeup Artist
Same hands, a ladder attached: BLS median $45,330 (Skincare Specialists), growth +9%, ~14,200 openings a year, and a 90th percentile of $82,050 — because master/advanced licence tiers gate the device work and physician offices pay a ~$51,600 median. Your sanitation exam, fine motor control and rebooking habits are most of the job already. First move: a 600–750-hour esthetics programme, then W-2 spa or med-spa employment while your book builds.	The needle-adjacent licensed seat: tickets of $400–$800 per procedure (brows $400–$800, lip blush $500–$900) with a built-in annual touch-up cycle at $200–$400, and a realistic gross averaging ~$55K (labelled aggregator figure, ZipRecruiter 2021 — no official median exists). The industry's own academy calls this phase a shakeout that removes under-trained entrants; enter trained (100 hours+) and the shakeout works for you. First move: learn your state and county body-art registration rules in writing.

Smart move: Sell what the substitute can't ship in a box: licensed device work, skin outcomes, pigment that lasts a year. Basic polish is now a retail product.
Where you land after: You land in licensed skin or pigment work where one appointment bills like a full day of basic manicures — and repeat demand is built into the service itself.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
CHECK THE	WATCH THE	PICK YOUR	CONVERT THE	TRAIN INTO	KEEP NAILS

STEP 1 — Check the ceiling

FREE · TODAY

- BLS: median $35,760, 90th percentile ~$50,140 — the entire ladder fits under $51K
- Your year-1 anchor is the 10th percentile: $28,920

STEP 2 — Watch the substitute

WEEK 1

- Price a quality press-on set against a basic salon manicure — your future clients already have
- List which salon services a box can't replace; that list is your target skill set

STEP 3 — Pick your door

WEEK 2

- Door A keeps the skin: esthetics, licensed, tiered, with device work above
- Door B keeps the precision: permanent makeup, $400–$800 tickets, touch-up annuity

STEP 4 — Convert the hands

WEEKS 2–4

- Sanitation, precision and client care are the transferable core — document them
- Nail hours don't transfer as credit; your steadiness and hygiene record do

STEP 5 — Train into the ceiling-free seat

WEEKS 3–10

- Esthetics: 600–750 hours. PMU: a 100-hour+ fundamental, never a 2-day intensive
- Choose by supervised practice and healed-result standards, not by price

STEP 6 — Keep nails as the side skill

ONGOING

- Premium custom nail art can ride along as a specialty once a licensed base pays the rent
- Basic manicures are marketing now, not a career

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Today: compare $35,760 (median), $50,140 (top decile) and the press-on price at the drugstore.

□ Days 1–30: substitute math done; door chosen; programmes vetted by clinic hours and supervision.

□ Days 31–60: training underway — skin or pigment fundamentals with real supervised practice.

□ Days 61–90: practice clients accumulating; employer or studio targets identified.

□ Day 90: you're building toward tickets and tiers that nails don't have.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **DON'T POLISH A CEILING.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.